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Ousted scientist wins $6m in lawsuit

Jury finds ex-colleague's sexual misconduct claims were defamation

By Tonya Alanez
GLOBE STAFF
and Madyline Swearing and Bryan Hecht
GLOBE CORRESPONDENT

A Suffolk County jury on Friday awarded $6 million in damages to ousted star scientist and former MIT professor David Sabatini, whose career imploded after he was accused by a much younger colleague of inappropriate sexual conduct in his Cambridge research lab.

The verdict was a stark rejection of a high-profile #MeToo claim from Kristin Knouse, a fellow scientist who said Sabatini had subjected her to a coercive relationship and fostered a hostile and sexualized workplace environment in his lab at the world-renowned Whitehead Institute.

The jury of seven women and six men directed Knouse — who had brought her own suit against Sabatini — to pay the $6 million verdict, plus interest, finding she had defamed him and interfered with his ability to make a living.

"We are so happy that we got David Sabatini's good name back," his lawyer, Lisa Arrowood, told the Globe. "Now he can be regarded as the brilliant scientist he is."

A 2021 internal investigation revealed that Sabatini's relationship with Knouse had violated a strict workplace relationship policy at Whitehead. Sabatini had been a rising star in

SABATINI, Page A10

T is making this No. 2 problem a No. 1 priority

Agency to try raptors to handle its pigeon problem

By Diti Kohli
GLOBE STAFF

Look anywhere — *everywhere* — outside the MBTA Tufts Medical Center station, and there are pigeons.

They lingered atop the street lights on a weekday afternoon and flapped around a traffic signal on Washington Street in Boston. One loitered on the arm of an unattended baby stroller. Another ambled about a huddle of cigarette smokers.

Tony James, a local hospital cook, inspected a de facto brick bench by the T station, smothered in bird droppings, before he cautiously lowered himself onto its very edge. A dozen winged rats inched toward him menacingly.

"If I'm honest," he said, "I was scared to sit down."

So how bad is the T's pigeon problem? (Bad, by the agency's own admission.) And how can it be fixed? (Not easily.)

Bird infestations and droppings are among the most common customer complaints the T said it receives. But the spikes, netting, and sonic repellent devices the agency already uses are no match for the feathered squatters, whose homing instincts can tie them stubbornly to one spot for most of their lives.

So the problematic poo hot spots abound. The birds' preferred T stations have little in common: North Station receives its fair share of 311 complaints to the city, and the T has previously named JFK/UMass and, of course,

PIGEONS, Page A5



DAVID L. RYAN/GLOBE STAFF

Pigeons, like this one perched at the Tufts Medical Center T stop, have a homing instinct that makes them hard to deter.

The women said Brown wouldn't stop calling them even after they blocked his number.

Suspect faced other complaints

Before Martha's Vineyard rape charge, former girlfriends had restraining orders against him

By Lea Skene and John R. Ellement
GLOBE STAFF

In the weeks and months before Edward J. Brown was charged with raping a woman at the State Police barracks on Martha's Vineyard, two ex-girlfriends of the Boston Public Schools safety official obtained restraining orders against him, alleging harassment and other alarming behavior.

Brown, 27, appeared in court twice to defend himself. The most recent hearing was Aug. 17 — two days after Brown is accused of raping a woman in the barracks on Martha's Vineyard, where he was staying with a trooper friend.

Details revealed in the recent civil court proceedings raise new questions about Brown's personal life.

In both cases, filed in Dorchester Municipal Court, the women said Brown wouldn't stop calling them even after they blocked his number, according to recordings of the proceedings obtained by the Globe. They said they feared for their safety.

As a result, records show Brown was ordered to surrender his firearms. One of the orders is active through August 2027, meaning he was prohibited from possessing guns until then.

Despite the court order, Brown continued serving as assistant director in the Office of Emergency Management, under the BPS Department of Safety Services, a role that includes planning and conducting active shooter training, fire drills, and safety audits. He was placed on leave after his arrest on the rape charge last week.

BPS officials initially said they were not aware of any restraining orders "as Brown passed all required background checks." But BPS spokesperson Sujata Wycoff

RAPE, Page A6



Healey response to police barracks case falls short for some



PHOTOS BY JONATHAN WIGGS/GLOBE STAFF

Prosecutors say that Edward J. Brown attacked the victim at the State Police barracks in Oak Bluffs on Martha's Vineyard (top) and that earlier, the two had met at the Ritz Cafe in Oak Bluffs (above).

By Matt Stout
GLOBE STAFF

Shortly into her debate with challenger Michael Minogue Thursday night, Governor Maura Healey faced a question that's been put to her and many governors before: How, if given four more years in office, would she change the "culture of misconduct" in a State Police department riddled with it?

Healey's response: She is "proud" of the State Police, and her hand-picked leader, Colonel Geoffrey D. Noble, is doing wonderfully.

But it's what she said immediately before that touched a nerve.

The background to the question was the scandal that erupted this week after a man was charged with raping a woman he brought back to the State Police barracks on Martha's Vineyard while staying there as a guest of a state trooper, raising a host of questions about protocol in the department's facilities.

"Do things happen? Sometimes things happen," Healey responded. "But I can tell you, [Noble] and I make sure that swift action is taken."

By Friday, Healey's remarks in the debate response stung some advocates for survivors of sexual assault. They worry that in an environment already super-charged amid reports of a brutal gang rape at Cornell University, what state leaders say — and the message it sends to survivors — matters even more.

HEALEY, Page A6

Maine town wary of underwater data center

But developer sees plan as win-win solution

By Sabrina Shankman
GLOBE CORRESPONDENT

Nobody wants a data center in their backyard. So a developer from Needham came up with a novel idea: Sink a data center under the ocean off Downeast Maine and harness the motion of the extraordinarily strong tides there to power it.

He says it's a solution that could neutralize some of the main objections to data centers — they use up too much fresh water and energy, and they release too much heat.

"Tidal currents are free, continuous, and completely predictable, unlike wind or solar," said developer Louis Wolfson. "And the ocean naturally cools things without touching a single drop of drinking water."

But it turns out people don't like underwater data centers either. Though the idea at this point is little more than "an idea on a bar napkin," as the Eastport city manager put it, opposition is building fast.

In August, the City Council announced a 180-day moratorium on data center development. The council and the local port authority are opposing the project. And a group of residents has organized — Eastport Residents for Healthy Oceans — in part around their concern that if the developer gets an initial permit for a study, it could be harder

DATA CENTER, Page A10

A teacher was praised for tackling the shooter who attacked an Oregon elementary school before the assailant was shot by a father who followed him into the building. **A2.**

President Trump's new press secretary, Katie Zacharia, was forced out of her role after five days on the job. **A2.**

The jury in Matthew Farwell's federal trial heard explicit text messages prosecutors say he exchanged with Sandra Birchmore. **B1.**

Billionaire Boston philanthropists Rob and Karen Hale are donating $50 million to the Breast Cancer Research Foundation. **D1.**

Fall, guys

Saturday: Sunny, windy. High: 51-56. Low: 35-40.

Sunday: Sunny. High: 50-55. Low: 42-47.

High tide: 4:31 a.m. 4:37 p.m.

Sunrise: 6:59 Sunset: 5:59

Comics and Weather, **D4-5.**

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